AN OPEN RESEARCH PROPOSITION / DISCUSSION DRAFT

The Political Economy of Imperial Accumulation

A proposed collaborative programme of theoretical, historical and empirical research.

How is imperial accumulation constituted and reproduced through interacting economic and political mechanisms, and under what conditions can those relations be transformed?

The intellectual proposition

Research on imperialism has generated influential, and at times conflicting, explanations of unequal exchange, colonial drain, international value relations, monopoly, labour and resource appropriation, and uneven development. These approaches differ in their objects, levels of abstraction, theoretical assumptions and methods. Their disagreements are substantive; they cannot be resolved by simply placing them alongside one another.

Yet the historical processes these approaches seek to explain may be connected in ways that are obscured when each is examined separately. This initiative asks whether investigating those connections can advance our understanding of imperial accumulation as a historical process. It does not privilege any single theory or presume that competing accounts can be reconciled.

The object of inquiry is the historical process, not the construction of a unified school. Explanatory differences may prove productive precisely where they reveal conflicting accounts of causation, historical specificity or the relations between production, exchange and political power.

Three provisional lines of inquiry

1. Mechanisms and relations. How do forms of appropriation, value transfer and economic dependence arise, interact and change? Which apparent connections can be demonstrated historically, and which remain contested?

2. Conditions of reproduction. What political, institutional, productive and material capacities make these relations possible and durable? How are such capacities themselves produced and reorganised?

3. Contestation and transformation. How are relations of appropriation and dependence challenged or displaced? Under what conditions do alternative political and material capacities emerge, connect and endure?

An open, collaborative investigation

The programme would bring together researchers whose accounts of imperial accumulation need not be theoretically compatible. Its value would lie in sustained inquiry into the historical relationships among their explanatory objects, with differences made explicit rather than smoothed over.

Possible activities

- Focused discussions and workshops on substantive explanatory disagreements.
- Comparative historical studies of production, exchange, appropriation and political organisation.
- Transparent reconstruction and examination of quantitative models and their assumptions.
- Shared documentation of datasets, methods, evidence, limitations and unresolved questions.

Existing resources and possible infrastructure

The Unequal Exchange Toolkit is an existing, independently developed open research resource, with a methods library, data catalogue, documentation and experimental tools. It could offer useful technical and methodological support to the proposed programme. It does not define the programme's theoretical position, and participation would not imply endorsement of unequal-exchange theory.

Additional resources, publication arrangements and collaborative processes would be developed in consultation with interested researchers. Contributions need not require familiarity with GitHub or programming.

A possible initial phase

An initial six-month pilot, subject to discussion and funding, could convene a small research workshop; produce a jointly shaped agenda identifying major explanatory questions and disagreements; document selected methods or calculations; and establish a practical process for sharing working materials. The scope, participants, outputs and budget remain to be agreed.

Invitation to discuss

This prospectus is an invitation to help define the questions and assess whether a collaborative programme would be worthwhile. It is not a declaration of theoretical consensus, a list of confirmed participants or a funding commitment.

Programme page: unequal-exchange-toolkit.github.io/toolkit/programme/